party arrived for the first time at this ancient site of pilgrimage with its camphor lamps, murmuring voices, and the staccato claps of qawwali singers. Akbar then travelled to Sambhar where he stopped for a day and acquired not just a bride, but the unswerving loyalty of her entire clan.

The bride who left her natal Rajput clan in Amer to enter the unknown world of the Mughal harem was Harkha Bai.[*] But the young woman did not enter unaccompanied into her new world, for she had a veritable cuirass of brothers and nephews to walk beside her. At Ranthambore, as the Mughal party proceeded towards Agra, they were greeted once again by Raja Bharmal and his sons and brothers. There was also present a young boy, twelve-year-old Man Singh, now released from the isolation that had been suggested by an astrologer.[†] Popular legend has it that when Man Singh greeted Akbar for the first time, the Padshah looked affectionately at the sprightly but dark-complexioned young boy and jovially said to him, 'Well, Man Singh, where were you when God was distributing beauty in heaven?' To which, it is believed, Man Singh replied with verve and panache, 'Shahenshah! I was in my prayer room at that time but I was present to receive valour and manliness when the almighty in her mercy was distributing the same.' Apocryphal or not, the story illustrates the legend of Akbar and Man Singh's great bond of loyalty and love which would make the Rajput one of the greatest noblemen of the Padshah. Man Singh would travel far from his natal clan into the furthest corners of the Mughal Empire, the Padshah's most trusted liegeman.

The large retinue that accompanied Harkha Bai and the Mughal party included the bride's brother, Bhagwant Das, her nephew, Man Singh, as well as a large number of female attendants to perform the various tasks that Harkha Bai would require: dhai maas (wet nurses), dholans (female drummers), purohits (priests), nayans (barbers), darjans (tailors), varies (cooks), and davis (maids), collectively called the zenana amla, accompanied their princess to her new marital home. For the Rajputs kept their women in seclusion in a space called the zenana deorhi in which female staff provided all the services required. As Harkha Bai was carried along in her sequined palanquin and her brothers and relatives accompanied her on horseback, this entire microcosm of Rajasthani culture also headed to Agra, bringing with them their songs, their dances, their food, their customs, and their tenacious dreams.

♦